

COMS3011A Project 6

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1 Wits Quest

Inspired by Pokemon Go and tired of the current tours, a lecturer wants to build a web game that gets students (and anyone else) to explore campus. When a player is close to an event, they can participate in a game based off alumni, history, landmarks and any other trivia about the university. If a player is correct or wins the game, they are awarded collectible cards with attributes and properties that can be used in a turn based poke-battle-esque minigame with other players or CPUs.

1.1 Features

1.1.1 Basic

The game is played on a map of campus, so a player should see where they are and what is near them. Events sit at chosen locations, each active within a radius and for a period of time. A player should be able to tell at a glance which events are in reach, which are too far, and which have passed.

Getting to an event is what the game asks of a player, so the game has to establish that they actually did. A player's device reports where it is, and that report should be treated as a claim to be checked rather than as fact. Someone who is not at the location should not be able to attempt its challenge. This sits underneath everything else, because a card is only worth collecting if it had to be walked to.

An event should ask something about the university, drawn from its alumni, its history, its landmarks, or any other trivia worth knowing, and it should not always ask in the same form. Answers should be marked by the game rather than by the device, and a player should come away knowing the answer whether or not they got it right.

A correct answer awards the card tied to that event, once. Cards carry a category and a set of attributes, and some should be harder to come by than others. A player should be able to look through what they have collected.

Those cards are then played. A player should be able to choose a deck and play a turn-based match against the computer, picking an attribute and comparing it round by round. The rules of a match should be the game's to enforce, not the player's, and finished matches should be kept.

None of this exists without content, so the game's authors need a console: to place events on the map, write questions and their answers, and define cards and the attribute values they carry.

1.1.2 Intermediate

Campus is a poor place to depend on a connection. A player inside a building with no signal should still be able to explore, open an event they have reached, and answer it, with the attempt held on the device until there is a connection again and checked then as it would have been at the time.

The check on where a player is should become harder to fool. The game should consider how a player has been moving rather than only where they currently claim to be: journeys nobody could have walked, attempts made faster than the walk between them allows, and the places where a location fix is too poor to rely on and something else has to show a player was there.

Playing the computer should become playing people. A player should be able to challenge another, each taking their turn when it suits them, with the game holding the match in between and a player who abandons it forfeiting eventually.

There should be a reason to keep playing: a profile, points, achievements, days kept up in a row, and standings against everyone else. The cards should carry some of that, with rarer cards, duplicates that are worth something rather than dead, and decks assembled under constraints instead of freely.

Events should also join up into trails completed in order, and the game should point a player towards what is nearby and still unvisited.

Authoring should become curation. Content should be drafted, reviewed, and published rather than going live as written, campaigns scheduled around a term or an open day, old events retired, and questions everybody gets wrong surfaced so they can be repaired.

1.1.3 Advanced

Turn-based play should become live. Two players should be able to play the same match at the same time, with the game holding what is true about it, turns timed, and a player who drops out able to return to where they left off. Others should be able to watch a match in progress.

A game that hands out rewards for being somewhere will be cheated, and the checks below only catch the careless. The game should build a picture of each player over time, from movement that could not have happened, submissions sent more than once, and accounts that only ever play each other, and use it to decide how far a player is trusted. It should answer with something proportionate rather than a single ban, and suspect players should surface on the console for a person to judge. This is the hardest part of the game: deciding what really happened from evidence supplied entirely by the party with a reason to lie.

Placing every event by hand does not last. The game should be able to distribute events across campus itself, keeping to where people can actually walk, holding them apart, keeping a sensible number live at once, moving them around over time, and never leaving one part of campus permanently bare.

Competitive play should be organised, with players rated, matched against others of similar standing, and seasons that start over.

Campus itself should become contested. Zones should be held and taken by players, with many of them acting at once and the game settling what happens when they do.

Players should be able to trade, with an offer from each side and an exchange that either completes for both or not at all, held within limits that stop it being used to pour a collection into one account.

The console should show how the game is actually being played: which locations draw people and which are ignored, which questions are too easy to be worth asking, and whether cards are coming out at the rate intended.

External Brief: A supplementary brief for this project, written by its proposer, will be provided to the group assigned to it.

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